

Muslims in REVOLT

With polls drawing near, Muslims launch their own political parties and stitch new alliances

| By Farzand Ahmed |

Come election season and the M-word begins to resonate in the nation's political mindscape. This time around, the poll dynamics of the community have gone into overdrive after the new-found friendship between 'Maulvi' Mulayam Singh Yadav and 'Hindu Hriday Samrat' (emperor of Hindu hearts) Kalyan Singh triggered the mushrooming of political outfits across the nation. Maulana Badruddin Ajmal, founder of the Asom United Democratic Front (AUDF) which won 13 seats in the 2005 Assam polls, came to Delhi to announce a pan-India Muslim party, the first since Independence, with units in Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar and Jharkhand. An alumnus of Deoband, he has the backing of the Dar-ul-Uloom, Jamaat-ul-Ulema Hind, Jamaat-I-Islami Hind and Nadwat-ul-Tameer. The AUDF seems set to contest 20 seats in Uttar Pradesh, 10 in Maharashtra and nine in Assam.

Similarly, the month-old Ulema Council (UC), created to fight "state terrorism against Azamgarh's innocent youth" and to demand a judicial inquiry into the Batla House shootout, declared it would 'bury' Mayawati's elephant and 'puncture' Mulayam's bicycle in this election. Its February 20 rally at Lucknow reflected the mood of the Muslims who feel they are the victims of political gamesmanship. Sonia Gandhi was referred to as *sunehri nagin* (golden serpent) and Mayawati *kali nagin* (black serpent). Mufti Abdullah Phoolpuri, one of UC's top lead-

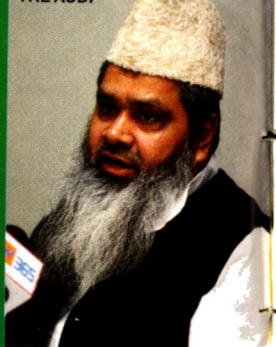
THE EMERGENCE OF THE ULEMA COUNCIL AS A POLITICAL OUTFIT IN UTTAR PRADESH MIGHT EVEN POLARISE THE VOTERS, GIVING AN EDGE TO THE BJP.



Latest Alliances

The last few weeks have seen the birth of many political outfits with a clear agenda

AJMAL OF THE AUDF



YASBANT NEGI

ers, said it would field its own candidates as most leaders forget the community once elected.

Meanwhile, Salim Peerzada, president of the Parcham Party of India (PPI), which has been contesting elections since 2002, has cobbled together a new front consisting of PPI, the All India Muslim Masjid and the National Loktantrik Party (NLP)—all of who have contested elections. "We want to create a 21st-century party, a secular-democratic outfit. Our objective is to help create a third front of Muslim-led, leftist, secular and centrist parties. We want to live in a democratic set-up and get our due, but not by extra-constitutional means," says Peerzada. The trend is clearly national. Tamil Nadu, for in-